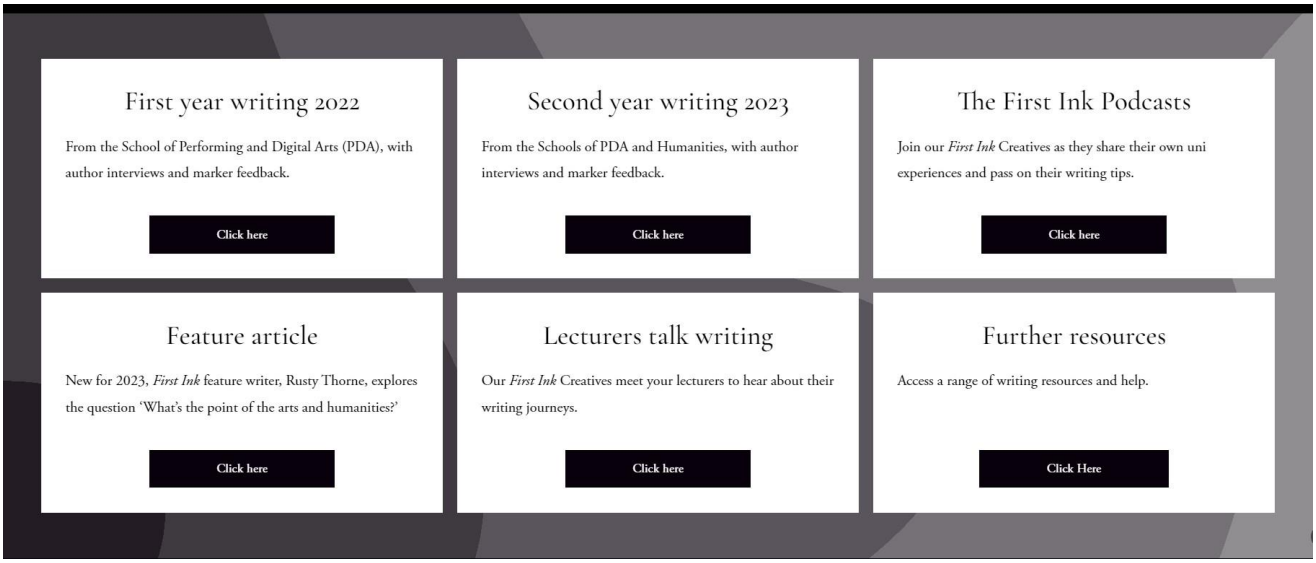
A guide to using *First Ink* in your teaching



Introduction

This quick guide is for academics in the Schools of PDA and Humanities who would like to make use of *First Ink* as a resource in their own teaching, whether in tutorials or module sessions. The more *First Ink* is integrated into learning and teaching, the more likely it is that students will get to know what it has to offer and go back to it for support.

What is *First Ink* and what does it aim to do?

First Ink is an online learning resource with the look of a blog or magazine. It showcases first-class written assignments that have been shortlisted by academics and selected for publication by a panel of student judges.

First Ink is a website but students access it via a gateway Moodle page. Please find the link to the Moodle page below:

First Ink - exemplary writing by students for students

A key premise behind *First Ink* is that exemplars of student work can help make tacit knowledge about academic writing visible as well make disciplinary notions of quality clear. Students can find a range of assignment genres from discursive essays to critical reflections and briefing papers. Currently, the pieces are taken from first year (PDA only) and second year modules. Each published piece is accompanied by an interview with the student author, a marker commentary and (for many pieces) inline annotations. Along with podcasts, lecturer advice and other resources, *First Ink* sheds light on the craft of good academic writing - what it looks like on the page, what inspired it and how it was put together.

How to introduce *First Ink* to your students

It is certainly helpful to point out where students can find *First Ink* on Moodle, but this might be a first step. Better still, do one or more of the following:

- Place a link to *First Ink* in your module page on Moodle – preferably, somewhere not too tucked away.
- Spend a couple of minutes providing a quick tour of *First Ink* - where to find the exemplars, the author interviews and commentaries but also some of the other resources.
- Give your students a 5-minute treasure hunt: three or four questions that will encourage students to explore different parts of *First Ink* to find the answers.

When introducing *First Ink* to your students, it is worth underscoring a key caution about exemplars: they should always be approached *critically*. The *First Ink* pieces are not templates to be copied in an unthinking way but, rather, represent diverse ways in which student writers tackle their assignments.

Ideas for engaging students with First Ink through learning activities

Please find below some suggestions for activities that could form part of a tutorial or a module workshop. Note that that they are only suggestions – you may well have much better ideas! Many of the activities involve close analysis of exemplar work with the aim of illuminating the different ways competent student writers communicate on the page. And this has a further benefit. Looking through writing with a beady, noticing eye helps develop a skill that students can apply to their own work as an essential part of the drafting and editing process.

To Note

- When picking out pieces from *First Ink* for an activity, bear in mind that some pieces are more in need of improvement than others. So, an especially impressive essay might suggest an activity where students are asked to pick out 'three things from this essay that I would like to emulate in my own writing'. Another piece might lend itself better to an activity where students identify both strengths and weaknesses.

- *First Ink* was launched in 2022 as a PDA initiative with a focus on first year writing. It became a joint initiative with Humanities in 2023. That's why there are currently no first-year exemplars from Humanities – although this is something that may well be remedied in a future update.

<u>Identifying strengths and weaknesses</u>

Go to the marking criteria and highlight the key things that markers are looking for in first-class writing. Now ask students to prepare a short oral or written critique on a selected piece from *First Ink* which identifies key strengths and weaknesses. At the tutorial or module session, pair up students and ask them to compare critiques. Finally, direct them to the marker commentary that accompanies the piece – were students and marker struck by the same things? How far did they agree on strengths and weaknesses?

<u>Noticing purposeful use of sources</u>

Ask students to read through a particular section of an essay. In pairs, students discuss these questions:

- Why has the writer chosen to summarise a source rather than quote - and vice versa?
- How successful is the writer at integrating sources into the flow of a sentence or paragraph?
- Why is the writer using sources – to provide an overview of a debate, to help support and develop the writer's own argument, to provide a springboard for a counter-argument, or for some other purpose?

Style matters

With students, brainstorm a list of what constitutes an academic writing style and unpack things like 'concision', 'formal register', 'coherence and cohesion' and 'clarity' or 'elegance'. You may want to underscore the roles of writer's purpose, audience and assignment genre (e.g., discursive essay, report, critical reflection) in determining matters of style. Ask students to apply the agreed list of style pointers to a page or two from a *First Ink* piece. Then share and discus critiques – and revise pointers as necessary. This could be followed up by peer review of their own draft assignment work, applying the (revised) list of pointers.

Mapping argument threads

Ask students to reverse engineer the argument for a section of writing from a *First Ink* piece. To do this, ask them to translate the writer's thread of discussion into a route map that traces each step in the discussion, sentence by sentence. Looking at the finished route map, does it navigate a clear, logical path through the topic? Are there any unnecessary steps that could be cut out or steps that could be re-ordered? Explain that such reverse engineering is a useful noticing/editing technique that allows a writer to become a stranger to their own writing. If time allows, ask students to apply the technique to their own draft writing.

Beginnings and endings

Ask students to brainstorm what makes an effective essay introduction and conclusion. You may want to add to the discussion by clarifying your own expectations about the 'thesis statement' - what it is and whether it is needed – as well as your expectations on use of the first person. Now ask students to read an essay (or two) from *First Ink* to see if introductions and conclusions match expectations or perhaps deviate in interesting, productive ways.

Digging down into process

There's always a story behind a piece of writing and it's about process: what inspired the writing and how it was put together over time. *First Ink* aims to open up these stories about process.

Ask students to read a piece – written by a student or one of the featured lecturers – and then listen to the accompanying interview in which the author reflects on how they went about writing their essay, article or chapter. Students can also listen to one of the podcasts for further insight into the research-writing process. Then ask students to pick out approaches that they hadn't thought of before and could try out. It could be a tip about time management, note-making, drafting, editing - or even attitude.